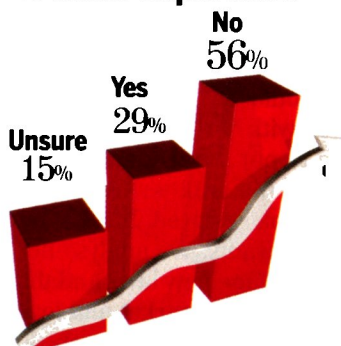


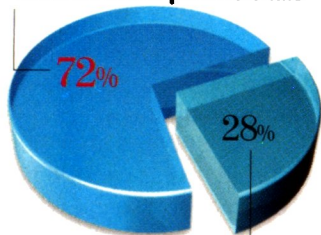
WHAT MEN WANT

Is caste important?



Want a working wife?

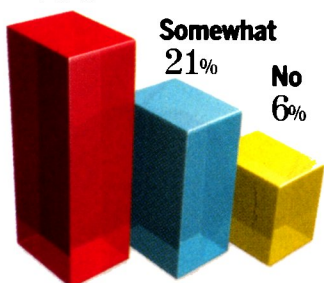
Want doctors, engineers, MBA and other professionals



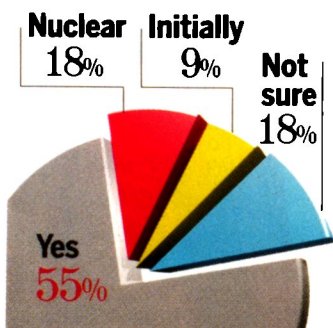
Not sure what sort

Does courtship help?

Totally
73%

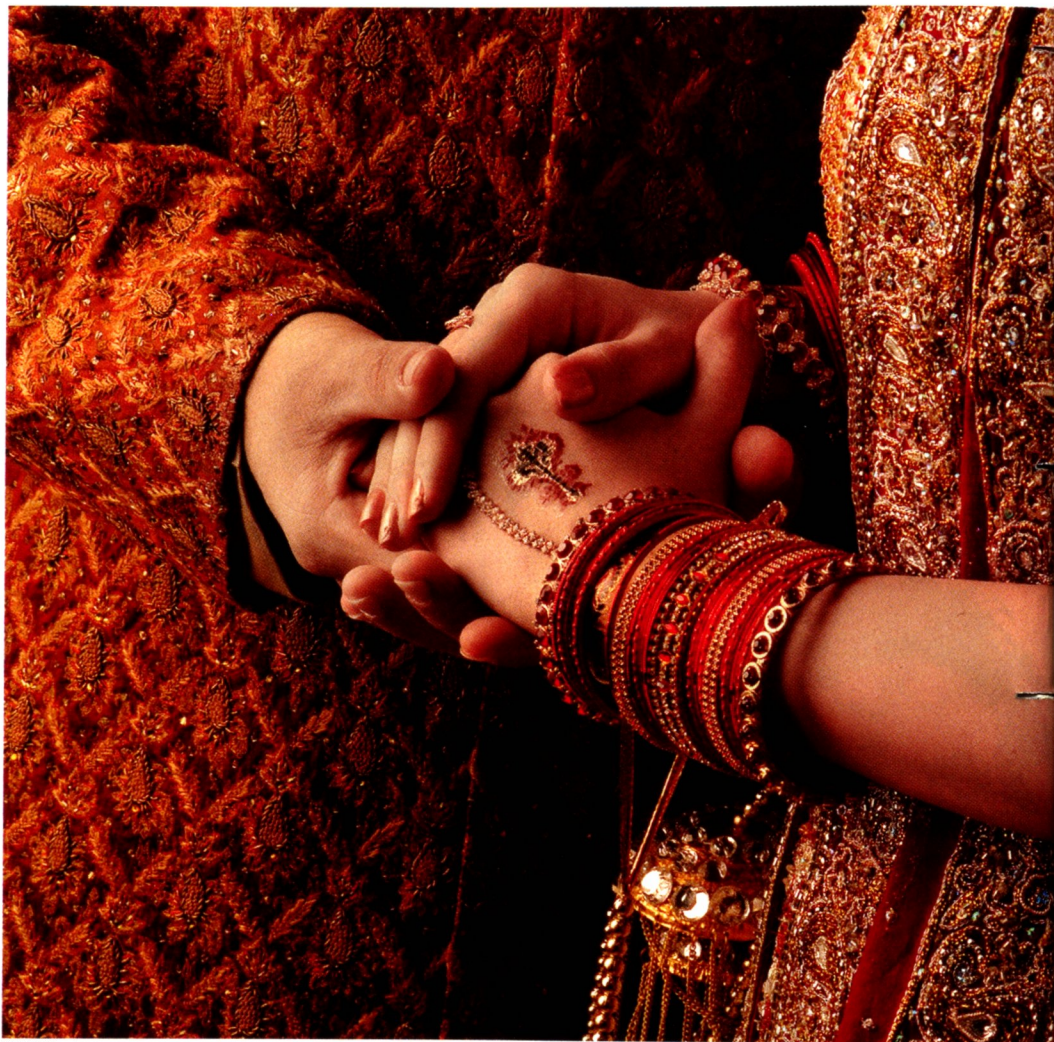


Prefer a joint set-up?



Source: Shaadi.com, "Shades of Shaadi: A Partner Preference Survey, 2009"

PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com



BANDEEP SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

seem to be shifting—seemingly for the better.

Newspapers reflect the fast-changing prototype of the "suitable girl" over the years. "The demand for a pretty, virgin, accomplished bride from the right caste and family was prominent in the 1960s," says Ranjana Kumari, director of the Centre for Social Research, Delhi, who studied 3,200 matrimonial ads published between 1967 and 1997 ('Indian Marriages: Economic Independence & Changing Power Relations', 2004). During the '70s, words like, "convent-educated," "homely,"

"smart" and "fair" started popping up. Physical beauty—"tall, fair, slim"—became a big issue in the '80s. The preferred '90s woman was a professionally qualified, physically perfect, individual who also needed to be a "homely daughter-in-law", matched to perfection by the stars and planets. "Physical attributes of the woman grew to be the primary parameter of success in the marriage market throughout the period of the study," she says.

That vision of the ideal *bahu* was imagined by parents, the primary movers and shakers behind

arranged marriages in India. But, in a new turn, the authority of the old guard seems to be slipping. Now, as the Shaadi survey reveals, parents seem happy to leave the quest to their children, especially sons. "My parents encourage me to look for my life partner," says 25-year-old Delhi engineer, Vikas Kumar, about his liberal army officer father and home-maker mother. He is not alone. About 82 per cent urban men are posting profiles and searching for "my kind of girl" themselves (just 58 per cent women are doing so). Parents are also asking